

7-DUMB-ASS BRANDING
Mistakes
(you can't afford to make.)

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Many of us dream of creating a successful business and changing the world for the better. We fantasize about hitting the big time, making our mark, enjoying the American Dream, and never having to worry about money ever again. It's in all of us. That idea, that feeling. That calling...

And, the great thing about America is that no matter who you are, no matter what you came from, how great or terrible your childhood was, how fantastic or nightmarish your life has been so far, success is available. It really is doable. The American Dream is alive and well, and it's available to those who get up off that sofa, look up, and say I'm not living life to the fullest yet. I need something better, something more. For those who are willing to take the risk, do not quit at the first challenge and find solutions to get your idea off the ground. Success awaits.

I know this first hand because I came here with just a suitcase and a dream, so inspired by the 'idea' of America: the land of opportunity, the land of the free. BRAND AMERICA, I was hooked. And even though my beginning was rough, starting with next to no money, going flat broke, not knowing what to do, but knowing I had to make it happen or I would not eat, I found how determination can turn into knowing. And despite that rough start, after just seven years, I was not only wealthy beyond my dreams but so incredibly fulfilled, having created a go-to brand in my industry, landed on the front page of the Wall Street Journal, and working

with some of the best-known clients in the world, like Nike and Ralph Lauren. Not only did I build my brand, but I learned from the brand masters. My company ended up helping those brands become even more successful. And now it's your turn. Because the beautiful thing is a successful brand delivers sales to you. In fact, a successful brand enjoys the equivalent of a line out the door while other companies wonder where all the people are.

And as you experience the world of business, as you learn what works and what doesn't... at some point, we find ourselves wondering... why are people doing business with me? Or why did my potential customer buy from someone else when I knew my company could do the job better? How can I get more sales without it costing all my profit? As we grow, our problems change. As we experience business, we start seeing how some companies really thrive while others just fall by the wayside. And that burning question becomes a drumbeat of urgency: How do we get more sales?

The words “There are masses of people simply waiting to do business with you, once they are so inspired” are the first you will read in my award-winning best-selling book (World Famous: How to Create a Kickass Brand), and you will hear me say it often too. No matter how amazing your product or service is, it's how your brand inspires people that makes all the difference. The secret to success in business is not simply about selling products or services;

it's about relationships, trust, and safety. It's about psychology and understanding who your customers are and what is really most important to them.

These seven DUMBASS branding mistakes (you can't afford to make) will help guide you to an essential group of conclusions:

- You can have a brand your customers LOVE
- America IS the land of opportunity
- The American Dream is alive and well
- Creating a go-to brand is the secret to business success
- Go-to brands attract more sales, profit, and value than non-brands
- Non-brands are VENDORS
- DO NOT MAKE THE MISTAKE OF BEING A VENDOR

If you, or anyone you know in business, says, 'My market is everyone,' they (or you) will be broke forever. Even Elon Musk, Oprah Winfrey, and Rihanna understand they cannot sell to everyone. Only businesses that act as vendors believe they can sell to everyone.

The word VENDOR is a word you must avoid, like the plague. Others can be vendors... you MUST NEVER BE one. The only way to develop a sustainable, evolving, in-demand business is to build a brand. People don't have relationships (generally) with finite objects; they do have relationships with brands, though. You

will recall either yourself or a friend even using the word ‘love’ to describe a brand. This is your goal: once you discover your formula for your customers to say they ‘love’ your brand, then continue to evolve those attributes your customers just can’t get enough of.

The simple worst mistake businesses make is to enter the vendor trap. We focus on this specifically in step 4. However, ALL the DUMBASS steps are designed to help remove you from or avoid the vendor trap. It’s human nature to become a vendor, just like it’s human nature to eat fries and a Coke. Once we understand what’s best for us, then it’s up to us to stay focused, disciplined, and true to our vision.

You see and experience vendors every day. They are the mass. The bulk of businesses that do not inspire you, the mass of businesses trying to sell you their wares. They are the businesses you use, then go somewhere else or just forget about. They do not resonate with you in any way other than the fact they sold you the thing you wanted at the time. That’s a vendor. Many vendors are simply focused on money. They say things like “it’s a numbers game,” and often they are unemotional about the business they have and the products or services they sell; some believe it’s all about the products or services they sell. Most specifically, they don’t know you. You are simply a transaction. They don’t know what is essential to you or inspires you, what you are about, or why you did business with them. Worse still. If you have a problem, they often

are not helpful. It's a customer-beware attitude, and it creates a fickle culture of people who only care about price.

The true secret to creating a brand for the people you want to do business with love is to avoid, like the plague, the following mistakes others make every day. Yes, sales are vital to business, AND building a kick-ass brand is your opportunity to take your business to places you only dreamed of.

For your KICK-ASS BRAND, avoid these

DUMB-ASS mistakes:

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE:

1. READ FROM START TO FINISH
2. DO ALL 7 EXERCISES STARTING WITH #7 AND WORK BACKWARDS
3. BE READY TO CREATE A BRAND YOUR CUSTOMERS LOVE.

Mistake #1.

DOMAIN

KNOW YOUR DOMAIN, YOUR KINGDOM, YOUR COMMUNITY.

DOMAIN: Who do you most want to help, and how do you want to help them?

Dumbass mistake #1 is to run your business without knowing your domain, your specific market, which often means trying to sell to everyone and anyone. For example, during the growth of my business, we decided that our best clients had 100+ retail stores. Selling to smaller store chains was much more work, budgets were lower, and those businesses considered us expensive because they were not ready for the value we offered yet. Importantly, though, we decided that the domain for our British antiques and relics, the community, and the market we would focus on was retail display. Later, we refined our domain to include large retailers (100+ stores) and large department store chains.

How can you operate without a domain, without community? No one is an island; no successful brand lives in a cave. Today, more so than ever before, you can build a domain, your

chosen community, right from your cell phone while sitting on the bus. The critical question you are asking when considering this point is: know your customer. Yes, you must be absolutely clear about who you most want to do business with. In politics, they refer to this group as their base. A good politician understands their base. They know what's important to them, what will please them, what will get them activated, and what will make them angry, frustrated, or activated. You must know this, too. Who is your business designed for? Whose lives do you want to improve? What do you understand about this group of people that is different from other groups of people who might buy the same product or service? Where else? What do they like about doing business with you? What occupies their mind? What are their frustrations and aspirations? The better you know your customers, the more quickly you can communicate with them in a way that will stimulate their inspiration. When you really see the core group or groups of people you most want to connect with, the more successful you will be at creating a domain and building your community of similar-minded people who share in common and enjoy doing business with you.

As our market evolved, we realized something essential. Our competitors were vendors focused on selling their stuff. We discovered our clients valued us understanding their brand and presenting brand stories with consistency across all locations. It

allowed us to get our teeth into strengthening our brand because we discovered our domain.

Nick Graham, the famous ‘Chief Underpants Officer’ at Joe Boxer, once said, “Your brand is the theme park and your product the souvenir.” It’s such a profoundly accurate line: What it means is that once people have fallen in love with your brand (your theme park) or understand they really can trust you, they will be inclined to buy whatever else you offer because you have *earned* their trust. Just like once you have decided to “Just Do It,” you might buy more Nike products, or once you know you love flying with Virgin Atlantic, you will be pre-determined to feel good about booking with Virgin Atlantic in the future. What you will also learn is that many other people love to ‘Just Do It’ and are eager to fly Virgin Atlantic. These are the people you can consider your domain.

There are the people you develop your brand community around, and you take time to learn. If you are Virgin Atlantic, for example, you would want to know why these people love flying with you. What is it about them that says Virgin Atlantic fits into the story of their life, solves their frustrations, and appeals to their aspirations? The more we know about our customers, the easier it is to create community and inspire a large group of brand advocates, brand ambassadors, and committed customers who help your brand become THE go-to brand rather than an ‘also-ran.’

Start your brand journey by avoiding the mistake of NOT knowing your customer WELL. True success is found by moving beyond demographics and into the world of psychographics whereby you know what makes your people tick, you understand them so well you know how to inspire them, appeal to them, make them happy, get them behind an idea and honestly buy into the adventure of your brand in a way they can live vicariously through it.

When your brand communicates its values, people who share similar values often prefer those brands. You can build a domain and a community in many ways. Gordon Ramsey, the famous British Chef, once turned around the fortunes of a faltering great British pub with a down-to-earth local campaign for “Real Gravy.” He taught his pub clients how to make the absolute best gravy for their roast beef dinner, helped the company get excited about the domain they served, and had the whole company hit the streets with samples, excitement, and an invitation to join the campaign for Real Gravy... so simple and such a big hit, the pub took off again. It was filled with happy customers, even the ones who didn’t care about gravy. When building your brand, think about how you can create a community of people who care about the same things your brand does. In today's world of social media and video, this is the perfect time to build community around your brand.

Most companies overlook this and simply spend on marketing and advertising. Building a domain with a community helps you develop a core of raving fans who will only do business with you despite knowing there are choices. They will advocate for you and assume the role of brand ambassadors when you inspire them with ideas, beliefs, and commitment.

Sometimes, the community can pay fees due to the benefits of participation. You will know if this is the type of business you run. However, no matter what business or organization, finding an emotional connection with your domain is the secret to becoming the go-to brand in your market. When you build and inspire community well, you can dominate your market rather than simply compete in it. Once the word is out about the consistently ‘unique’ and ‘valuable’ aspects of your brand, together with the other items in this guide, you can effectively enjoy a line out of the door of customers eager to do business with you.

How you communicate with your community is vital. You are most certainly allowed to pitch, market, and sell to them, AND you must also engage them, inspire them, and lead them. Educate them. Only a maximum of one out of every four messages should be aimed at sales. The other three should be aimed at reinforcing your community with reasons to care.

Use this space to list any questions, thoughts, and ideas you have about your Domain and brand community...

Mistake #2.

UNSEEN

DON'T LET CAMOUFLAGE MAKE YOU UNSEEN.

UNSEEN: Are you sure you know how to be seen as the GO-TO brand in your market? If there is a go-to brand in your market, what do they have that you don't? What do they do that you don't? And lastly, DO NOT COPY THEM!

Dumbass mistake #2 is to become invisible or very hard to differentiate from others inadvertently. It's unfortunately straightforward to be UNSEEN in business. In many cases, you might actually be putting time and resources into an activity that acts like camouflage—literally making your business or brand very hard to see. It doesn't mean you become invisible. This means that too many companies are hard to differentiate from one another. The big problem is, the more similar your business or brand is to others in your market, then what is it that is going to stand out as the reason to buy from you?

When I started in business, I learned that there was a go-to brand in my industry. I heard they had a 50,000-square-foot warehouse in New York, \$10M in inventory, and salespeople all

over the country. I had a garage in Orange County, \$2k in inventory, and my only salesperson was me. How could I compete with them? How could I suddenly get a 50,000-square-foot warehouse and \$10M in inventory, never mind hire all those salespeople? I felt crushed. I felt stuck, trapped, and gasping for breath. Then, one day, I learned about something I had that they didn't.... Manners! I discovered they were rude and didn't seem to respect their customers. They had gotten a bit big for their britches and were annoying people with their attitude and some of their 'take it or leave it' ultimatums. I learned I didn't need the warehouse or huge inventory because I had something my customers liked... fun, friendly, committed, dedicated, and a company that goes the extra mile. It took a little while, but soon, our reputation became known within our community. After 7-years in business, we were at the top of our game, with the go-to brand in our market, my picture featured on the front page of the Wall Street Journal, more money than I had ever imagined when growing up in a little town in the North of England, and something more, the great pride of creating a brand that delivered the American Dream to myself, my business partner, so many of our team and crew who supplied us. It was a true adventure. I even experienced clients telling me how they enjoyed living vicariously through the adventure of our brand journey.

When you act like the other companies in your market, expect very average results. When you dare step outside the box and

create a real brand that resonates with the people you want the attention of, you have the makings of creating a real go-to brand. You are taking steps to be seen. Not unseen.

In business, the more we emulate the actions of others in our market, the more invisible we become. The more complex your brand is in terms of differentiation from others, the harder it is for customers to choose you. Your job is to be SEEN. Your job is to make your brand easy to select. Your job is to make your brand so obvious a choice for your intended market that it becomes a foregone conclusion.

Your business must be seen, so do not follow or lead. Do not copy; be original. Do not say things you do not mean; do not make promises you cannot guarantee.

Do not pay for big ads when PR, social media, and video can accomplish so much more for you at a fraction of the cost.

There are more ways to be ‘seen’ than any one person could conjure up. Do not hide thinking you have to be a superstar speaker or seasoned performer; you don’t. You simply need to be dedicated to what you are doing and to the people you are doing it for.

For example, Imagine a restaurant catering to business clients in a downtown area of a city that also gave away business books, hosted business-oriented events, and encouraged deal-making, networking, and education, as well as its great food and

ambiance. Do you think it might earn a reputation as a good place for business people to go?

Imagine a dentist specializing in child dentistry who decorates the entire business using Disney and Marvel themes and gives away simple yet fun toys, books, games, and prizes. Takes fun photos and brings to life the whole story of the tooth fairy. As well as providing quality, affordable dental work. Can you imagine kids wanting to go to that dentist versus an everyday boring, easy-to-forget dental office experience (a vendor)?

Imagine a shoe company dedicated to providing homeless people with a free pair of shoes for every pair sold... masses of people joined the community because they felt so good getting a great pair of shoes and knowing they were also putting a pair of shoes on a homeless person's feet.

Imagine a driverless ride-share company with ambitions to turn car parks into natural parks and other community projects, further enhancing city living.

Imagine a plumbing company dedicated to water conservation and green, earth-friendly solutions that save you money, as well as excellent plumbing services.

These examples are both real and made up. They are examples of how a brand can indeed be seen, create a community around a specific idea or theme, and become the dominant brand in the market.

The clue here, the mistake you **MUST** avoid, is this: **YOU CANNOT AFFORD TO BE INVISIBLE**. You cannot afford to be the same as others who do what you do. You **MUST** decide what your brand cares about, not sometimes, but always, with passion and with leadership. You must discover different ways to maximize the value of what you offer, including how you position and package your brand.

In business, being seen is not about showing off. It's not about bling or opulence unless that is what your brand is about. Being seen is about caring for what you stand for, taking action, and being the mouthpiece for others.

The fantastic brand The North Face was started in 1968 by a man named Hap Klopp. It was not a multi-billion dollar brand on day one. It was two retail camping stores in California. The brand became 'seen' because of Hap's pioneering ambitions. His first breakthrough product, based on the brand ideas of 'good for the planet,' 'sustainable,' and 'pioneering new materials and solutions,' was an ultra-lightweight backpack; the backpack used carbon fiber and other cutting-edge materials, never used before in a backpack. This brand foundation stone gave rise to a whole new outdoor experience, allowing hikers and explorers to carry more food and water and go further and explore more of the wilderness. Outdoor adventurers grew very excited and dedicated to the North Face brand: The company found its way to being seen as one of the very

first advocates of equal pay for women, gay rights, and equality; they even created awards for the worst offenders to the environment and got in the headlines for standing up for green earth. Customers became vociferous brand advocates, they became dedicated, and the level of trust toward the brand became the envy of the business world. The North Face would even allow people to return sub-par products from other companies; they would repair tents, sleeping bags, and backpacks of competitor brands and further earn the respect of more customers. Today, the North Face enjoys a status few brands have ever accomplished. The North Face has become a part of the American experience, an icon of success, all because Hap chose to follow his amazing path rather than being just another camping shop.

You, too, have the ingredients to create the world's next massive hit, or if it fits your ambition better, you have the ingredients to be the go-to brand in your community, your town, your street, or even your family. Most importantly, the secret to being seen is to stand up for something that you care about, and that is important to your customers, even if they don't know it yet. You CAN do this, so just commit to not letting your brand be UNSEEN.

Use this space to list any questions or ideas you have about making sure your brand is SEEN...

Mistake #3.

MONEY

DON'T BLOW IT.

MONEY: Dumbass Mistake #3 is blowing through cash without a clear plan or simply not appreciating how important money is in order to remain in business and grow.

Stop and think. Carefully. When it comes to business, cash is king. Once you have no cash, you have no power, no ability to maneuver, and no ability to deal with unforeseen circumstances. It's so easy to spend money, but it's harder to negotiate and, more importantly, agree to terms that allow you to pay over time or, in the right circumstances, offer trade or partial trade on certain items in order to conserve cash. Again, it's about discipline, to hold off on what seems like a great deal today, yet your business is really not ready for 'it' yet. No matter what, you must do everything in your power to conserve cash and not overspend. I've met excited entrepreneurs eager to get started in business who run out and buy several expensive suits because they want to look the part, and before they know it, they are out of cash and getting a job again. Be absolutely clear about the minimum your business needs to spend

until it can pay for expenses, etc, via cash flow, NOT savings or investments.

1.INVESTMENT v EXPENSE: When it comes to your brand especially, the secret is to determine how each item you see you need to spend money on can become a revenue producer, I.e., an investment, rather than simply a cost of business. You can have a website that looks and feels right but doesn't generate leads, or you can have a website that does nothing but create leads. The same is true for your social media, videos, PR, and promotions. Once you are clear about what is most unique and valuable about your brand, you can then communicate it through each of your brand touchpoints and through each of the methods you utilize to attract customer attention.

2.SEQUENCING: When it comes to creating your brand, do NOT run and burn through your money on things you are not ready for yet. Sequencing is key. Therefore, don't spend yet on ANYTHING like your website, marketing materials, social media, videos, or even promotions until you know exactly why your customers should do business with you. It cannot only be lower prices (that's what vendors do). A few years ago, I spoke at a significant business event in Los Angeles. At the end of the presentation, a young lady came running toward me in hysterics, balling, almost out of control. I wondered what on earth I'd said to upset her. I discovered she was so upset because she had just paid

\$35k for a ‘Brand’ package that consisted of a new website, logo, brochures, business cards, embossed letter paper and envelopes, and even a pile of cheap pens with her logo on them. Everything she showed me was in grey with a meaningless yellow swirl on the top. The reason she was crying was because she realized during my talk that her \$35k package would do nothing for her business. It was dull and uninspiring, and it had nothing in it that made people want to know more, check out her website, pick up the phone, or visit her establishment. When you spend your money on your brand package, it is your job to make sure it packs a punch, wows people, and brings home the bacon, meaning it plays a relevant role in your customer journey, helps build your brand, and delivers potential customers.

3.BRAND MYTHS: When creating a brand, the first mistake most companies and organizations make is believing that once they have gotten a logo, website, etc., they have a brand. They do not. A brand, when boiled down to its essence, is what makes your business consistently unique and valuable to your customers. Consistently means that every time your customer interacts with your company, you can guarantee that they will enjoy the same level of experience and satisfaction as usual. Unique means your brand is different enough to almost feel like a ‘one-of-a-kind’ experience. It’s unique because it demonstrates a clear understanding of who its customers are and what is important to them. And Valuable because when it comes to creating a brand, it's about more than the product or

service. It's about how you communicate your brand value and deliver on it. It's about how your brand acts, what rules it operates by, what beliefs it stands for, what extra benefits (that don't cost much but are valuable to your customers) it delivers, and how your brand makes people feel.

Money cannot buy this. What you must do is take some time to get absolutely clear about why your business does what it does, what made you choose this type of business, and what you believe you can improve for people by being in existence.

4.FOR YOUR BRAND: List all the benefits of doing business with you and let that influence how you communicate. Therefore, the biggest mistake you can make when creating your brand is to start backward, from the outside, when the opposite is true. You must start from the core. The core of your brand is based on your Brand Vision, Brand Mission, Brand DNA, Brand Story, Brand Promise, and Brand Persona. Once you are transparent about these items, you will answer who you are as a brand, who your brand is designed for, why it's perfect for those people, what is unique about the brand experience that is valuable to your customers, and more. Once you have this information, money spent on websites, social media, marketing, etc, becomes an investment with an absolute return. I call it 'pre-marketing' rather than simply a cost that doesn't help you. Once you are clear about your brand, you need to be sure of the following: for each item you spend money on... Why do you

need it, what do you want it to accomplish for you, and how do you make it an engaging or even inspiring part of the customer journey?

Again, cash is king. It's easy at the beginning of your business journey to go and throw money around. When I got started in business, a consultant befriended us. He said he had some clients he wanted us to meet, so we drove with our friend to the sands of Newport Beach. These guys had a hot (read: expensive) condo right on the beach, brand new muscle cars in the driveway, top-of-the-line desks and chairs with the fastest computers money could buy. At the time, I remember thinking there was no way I could invite them to my house, which was a hot mess. My desk was two saw horses and some planks, and my car was lovingly called a 1978 Chevy Malibu Shit-heap, held together with duct tape. Once we got talking to these two guys, I quickly realized they were fakes. Full of bravado and ego, they bragged about how accessible business was going to be because they had what they said was "the inside track." I never learned what the inside track was, except that 6-months later, they had run out of money, had a huge falling out, and closed up shop. I doubt they followed our fortunes, but by conserving cash until we had cash flow, we were able to grow to \$20M with minimal borrowing. And once cash flow was good, yes, we lived like kings. And you can, too, but you must relish these things. You must earn them. They are best seen as rewards, NOT entitlement.

Use this space to list any questions you have about MONEY
and your Brand Core...

Mistake #4:

BRAND

WITHOUT A BRAND YOU ARE JUST A VENDOR.

Mistake #4: Do NOT fall into the ‘vendor trap’.

1.**BRAND:** Without a brand, you, indeed, are only a vendor. But let's ask the question no one asks... what is a brand? Are you sure you know? When I ask people brand-related questions, they often don't know exactly what to ask. The reason is that the word brand has huge applications, and it actually means different things to different people.

To the general consumer, a brand means ‘a type of’ something. People will ask what brand of car they bought or what brand of ice cream they prefer. What they mean is, what kind of car did you buy, or what type of ice cream did you get? I've been out on the streets with cameras and asked many people, from business executives to stay-at-home Moms, from factory workers to marketing students. Everyone knows their favorite brands and happily shares them, and when I then ask... “what is a brand?” we get a whole load of “erm” and “hmm, never thought about it” type

comments. The truth is while people use the word brand, most do not know what a brand is.

For those of us in business, a brand is very different from simply being a type of something. Your brand is the very entity that either attracts or repels customers. Your brand represents the very DNA of your business, from your brand vision and mission to your brand persona, attitude, story, and promise. And because your customers really don't know what a brand is, the only way they relate to your brand is by way of the EXPERIENCE you provide them.

Therefore, even though there indeed are many ways to define a brand, for creating a go-to brand that your customers love, then this is the best definition of a brand you should work with, as mentioned previously...

A successful brand is consistently unique and valuable to its customers.

Write that down memorize it. Put it on your office wall, your screen saver, or even on your business plan. Your brand must be UNIQUE in that it is not invisible, is not the same as others who do what you do, is easy to differentiate, stands for something memorable, and inspires you to buy. Your brand must be seen as VALUABLE to the customers you want to attract; therefore, without simply being the cheapest, your brand must offer a clear understanding, with solutions, of the plight of your customers. Your

brand should be able to deliver this uniqueness and value CONSISTENTLY. Therefore, what you determine to be essential elements of your customer experience must be delivered every time to the same standard as last time. Lack of consistency will cause you to lose customers quickly. Not being able to demonstrate what makes your brand both unique and valuable makes your brand invisible, so this mistake must be avoided so that your brand stays ahead by being sure you are a brand, being certain you are not a vendor, and acting accordingly.

The bottom line here is that it's so easy to misunderstand how to create a brand: It's all about what you communicate and how you communicate it. Colors and logos are a part of that communication, but they are not everything, and they are not the most important aspects of your brand either; they are simply the most tangible elements of your brand. A good brand promise can be far more valuable. Remember when Domino's Pizza made a promise that you would have FREE pizza if your order arrived 30 minutes or more from when you ordered? That promise attracted multi-millions of business. Quick.. what does the Domino's logo look like? What colors do they use? Do you care? Does any of that affect which brand of pizza you will buy? People don't remember nice, pretty, run-of-the-mill. They remember things that are different, unique, exciting, alluring or memorable. This is why your brand culture, your brand story, your brand persona, your promise, and the whole

brand DNA makeup must be thought about and discussed. This is simply too important to skip. Your fantastic future (or lack thereof) rides on the way your brand communicates and behaves with customers.

This is why being a brand is so important, and being a vendor is a giant trap. Brands understand that customers can relate to and have relationships with them, but not with a vendor.

In fact, we call it the vendor trap. You do not want your business to be a vendor, even though your instincts make you want to. People rarely remember vendors, have no connection to the vendors they buy from, and only seek the lowest price because vendors rarely offer more than a product or service. Brands provide more, specifically trust, confidence, and shared aspirations. It's easy to determine if you are behaving like a vendor... if you answer more than half the following questions with a yes, you are a vendor.

- Do you offer products, services, and customer experience similar to those of other companies in your field?
- Do you ever feel invisible in business?
- Do you see competitors getting business you should have gotten?
- Do you feel sometimes the only way to compete is with price?
- Do customers seem fickle and easily seduced by other deals?
- Do you know who your core customer is?

- Does creating a community around your beliefs seem like a waste of time
- Do you agree that business is a numbers game?
- Is your business always looking for new customers?

We are probably in agreement that you need and want a brand, but again, let's get absolutely clear about what a brand is, and is not:

Do not be fooled into believing your brand is all about the colors you choose. Your logo is not your brand; it is simply a marker that people can use to know they are in the right place. Think of the flag of a country. You need to see a lot more about a country than what its flag looks like ... you need to know the culture, the story, the laws, the rules, and your reason for going. Your logo can certainly help attract customers if designed well, and if you want to be seen, noticed, and recognized, then your brand behavior is much, much more important than the clothes it wears. The mistake you must avoid is thinking people will just 'get' your brand by looking at the logo, website, and social media. They won't. People need experiences. With a well-crafted brand, you have the opportunity to deliver valuable, sales-building experiences for your customers and potential customers by first stopping to think. Asking questions like, where does my business look and act just like everyone else who does what I do? What makes my business different from theirs? Better than them? More relevant to the customers I want to serve?

Easier to understand? Easier to say yes to? Then, focus on translating your thoughts about your brand culture, brand story, and brand attitude into specific experiences you can provide to your customers.

For example, just like before, think about the difference between the experiences you get simply with pizza... from the cheapest cheap to the most ultra gourmet, from fast food to gold leaf dining, from a US pizza truck to an authentic Italian passionate and sophisticated off the beaten track romantic dream. You have the power to decide on the exact experience you want for your customer. Amazon makes shipping simple, stress-free, and NOT a barrier to purchasing online: such a better experience than pretty much any other online retailer. There are myriad ways to fine-tune the ‘experiences’ you offer as a brand. Your secret is psychology. Understand how to reduce anxiety, create trust, and understand the aspirations of your market, and you will be positioned far more powerfully than any vendor ever could be. The more you focus on being a leader, not a follower, in business, the more you focus on giving a better, more inspiring experience, the more SEEN your brand will become, and your brand will be known for that very thing you decide is essential.

Use this space to list any questions you have about turning your business into a Brand...

Mistake #5.

ATTITUDE

A BAD ATTITUDE WILL KILL YOUR BRAND.

Mistake #5: Do not forget your actions must equal your words. Entitlement is a business and brand killer. Making up a brand but not being dedicated to it as an organization around your message is simply a vendor in disguise.

1.**ATTITUDE.** How many times have you decided never to do business with a company ever again? When it all boils down, the reason you came to this conclusion wasn't because the thing you bought broke, because you had an issue and needed a little help, or even because you didn't like what you purchased. The reason we never return is because of a bad experience or a bad attitude. Yes, of course, you cannot always please all customers, and we are not talking about one-off random experiences. We are talking about your brand's wholesale attitude.

Taking customers for granted is a bad attitude.

Not delivering a consistent experience is a bad attitude

Putting money ahead of your brand values is a bad attitude

You've been there before, where it just feels wrong. You just know certain places don't seem trustworthy or honest. You just know they are saying whatever it takes to try and get you to buy. Or

worse, they don't even listen and just try to sell anyway, or you simply just didn't feel appreciated for spending your money with that company, or you merely sense a feeling of complacency because they take you for granted. Some businesses make paying a stressful, frustrating experience. Other places just don't seem to care about your experience with them at all. I hate it when a company acts like they are too busy even to acknowledge me or, worse, think they are clever and can get one over on me. Then there are those other companies with ulterior motives and owners with such a huge ego the experience is all about them, not you. Or the sales team who know nothing about the product or service they are selling, or the restaurant that doesn't acknowledge your existence, or the contractor who can't be bothered to clean up after they finish. Recently, I worked with a company that had an owner who was a tyrant. Each person on the team was more afraid of him than of being honest or truthful with customers, and the result was a company that literally charged the total price for doing next to nothing. The single defining distinction between good and bad companies and brands is attitude, and attitude starts at the top. So, let's really focus. Let's not just say you need a good attitude; let's define what a winning attitude looks like and why you must develop one in order to grow your brand...

Do not skip this huge 'mistake waiting to be made.' If you don't have a specific plan for the attitude of your brand, then it will

never be consistent, customers will get confused, team members will be confused, and your well-crafted brand will lose credibility.

And, before we get to the ways to avoid this mistake, let's ask... Are you thinking of starting a business because you think it will make money even though you are not passionate about that exact business? If so, think CAREFULLY. How can you make this business fit your passion? How can you change course so that your love is well utilized and fuels the growth of your brand, rather than simply work in hopes of making money doing something you don't care about? That sounds like a bad job to me, not the adventure of building a brand your customers love and that changes your life forever.

When creating a brand, you must be dedicated, excited, and unstoppable, and you must INSPIRE your team, your suppliers, and your customers. Never allow your business to be treated as just another number. Be passionate and focused...

Map out the ATTITUDE of your brand; for example, it could be a very hip and trendy boutique or a traditional English tea parlor. The attitude you bring makes all the difference. For example, a traditional English Tea parlor could be a real uptight, stuffy, rules-oriented experience, or it could be the most elegant, fun, immersive experience you've ever had.

Is the attitude of your business that of passion and adventure, one of nurture and patience, one of leadership and inspiration, or

even one of simplicity, no frills, economy? Think about your attitude toward employees, toward leadership and training, toward motivation and inspiration, toward opening doors or making things happen. Do you use charm or directness? Do you believe the customer is always right? Where do you draw the line when it comes to customer demands? How do you deal with customer returns, complaints, and mistakes? What is your general attitude in life? Is it positive or negative?

Get absolutely clear about the attitude of your brand, then look at that attitude and determine where you want to apply it most. Where in the customer journey will they most experience the attitude of your brand? It most likely will affect how you market, communicate, organize, and lead your business.

Ultimately, however, the attitude of you as owner and of your brand as the entity with which your customers engage is a powerful determining force that will dictate the level of success your brand will enjoy.

A powerful, inspiring attitude will inspire people to return. A money-grubbing, greedy attitude will repel them. Customer experiences that have not been pre-planned, mapped out, and scripted will not be consistent for your customers, and you will confuse them. Ultimately, your brand must become a well-oiled machine that delivers, time after time, a consistently good customer experience every time people do business with you.

Use this space to list any questions you have about your
Brand attitude...

Mistake #6.

SEDUCTIVE BRAND MISSION

Mistake #6: Do not create a brand mission that is all about your business or shareholders. MOST BRAND MISSIONS ARE BORING; they get put in a desk drawer and forgotten about. YOURS MUST BE SEDUCTIVE.

1. THE SEDUCTIVE BRAND MISSION: Your brand vision is also referred to as ‘unobtainium’ because your brand vision is so big it most likely won’t be accomplished in your or any customer’s lifetime. Your brand Mission is all about what your business can and will achieve this lifetime to bring the brand closer to the brand vision goals you will set.

Most businesses, at some point, realize they need a mission statement, and most companies also create a downright boring, fall asleep, uninspiring mission one. Yes, if a company has investors, of course, we want them to get a great return, but does that statement get *you* all excited? Do you believe teams of employees get inspired to create great shareholder value that they will never see? Is it worth enacting a plan that rewards shareholders as the brand’s primary cause? Will it get anyone other than an investor excited? Your Brand’s mission Statement must be seductive. It must seduce us into wanting to be a part of it, wanting to feel that our involvement will

help the mission become ‘accomplished.’ So even though your mission statement might include the obvious items, like shareholder value, your true mission deserves to be seductive, exciting, challenging, and worthwhile. It **MUST** inspire everyone (not only shareholders).

You know that feeling when you didn’t want to go for that hike or that excursion, but someone inspired you to go? You went, and we were so glad you did. You felt that sense of accomplishment, of being alive, of doing something worthwhile. That’s what your mission statement should do. Your acid test is to have a mission statement that, in real time, elicits excitement and enthusiasm.

Ultimately, your brand mission statement is intertwined with all company activities.

Do not overlook spelling out clearly your brand mission for the business and brand you are building. Focus. Think **INSPIRATION**... your brand mission should guide what you plan to do and how you plan to do it. Your brand mission should read like a checklist of specific actions and goals that are measurable and tangible. Your brand mission can include numbers ... in terms of dollars for revenue, costs, number of clients/customers, time frame, number of employees, etc. However, the heavy-lifting details are best covered in your business plan, which is an extension of your Brand Mission. Your brand mission should also cover rules, methodology, and, most importantly, **WHY?** Your mission

statement must allow anyone reading it to understand why your brand mission is so important, how people will know when it is accomplished, and how their lives will improve as a result. Your brand mission has the power to inspire people and change their lives or put them to sleep. Which would you like? Your message of inspiration does not have to be out of this world; it simply needs to be necessary. Once you know what you want to say, here are the sections:

1. **TITLE:** Your title should be seductive and give a hint about where you are going.

2. **OPENING PARAGRAPH:** What are you doing, and why are you doing it? This is where you bring to life your seductive mission as a plan and as an exciting description of what you will be accomplishing for people and why.

3. **HOUSEKEEPING:** Here, you focus on items like shareholder value, numbers, time frames, markets, and products. However, remember, the bulk of detail is best saved for your business plan, such as methods of production and distribution, etc. because you do not need to get ultra-detailed here. Your business plan is where the details go. Your housekeeping information should give readers the knowledge you have thought about these items without having to cover every last detail.

4. **SUMMARY:** A straightforward summary inviting participation from those who are most dedicated.

Fedex could choose a brand promise, tagline, and/or mission statement that says “when it absolutely has to be there in the morning.” Tesla could say their mission is to free the world from fossil fuel. Once we use an inspiring reason behind our brand mission, all the numbers, time frames, and even shareholder returns make sense and can be quickly embraced when the Brand Mission includes some kind of ‘payoff’ for everyone involved, not just those few at the top; then you have a winning brand Mission.

The bottom line, your brand mission must be seductive. Write it, test it, and even do a social media survey. If it even hints at boring the very people you know it needs to inspire, then give it more attention. Ultimately, your Brand Mission should be something you are so proud of. It gets painted on the walls, it gets turned into billboard slogans, and it resides as a potent calling message for your business to adhere to.

Furthermore, both your brand vision and brand mission allow your brand to be embraced and understood by all involved. This helps everyone stay on the same page. It allows for consistency of excellent performance. It makes decision-making easier, and importantly, everyone can celebrate when milestones are accomplished and goals are met.

Bottom line: your seductive brand mission is about your business.

Mistake #7.

SEXY BRAND VISION

MOST BRAND VISION STATEMENTS ARE BORING; YOURS MUST BE SEX.

SEXY BRAND VISION mistake #7: Most businesses create a brand vision that is business-specific, and many replicate their brand mission; doing this can limit your biggest opportunity to differentiate your brand in the world.

Your sexy brand vision is about the ‘world’ that can exist because of your brand. Your sexy brand vision is vital, yet most companies do not have one. Your brand vision refers to ideas behind the brand that help guide the future. Of the companies that do have them, most are boring, corporate, and shareholder value-based. To avoid mistakes, yours must be SEXY. Do not overlook writing your business plan, including your sexy brand Vision and seductive brand Mission. Without a clear idea of who you are as a brand and how you see the possibility for the world that can exist as a result of your existence. Define this world in a way only you can; Start at the core. Forget money for your sexy brand vision unless yours can address the lives of people In significant ways.

To help you define your sexy brand vision, create an invisible bubble in front of your eyes. In that bubble, put the word MONEY. Let the bubble float up and to the left of your periphery, not out of sight but also not the main focus of your attention. Think bigger. Your SEXY BRAND VISION must be a vision that is worthy and almost impossible. Your brand vision paints a picture of what you believe in for people. It needs to be a vision that inspires you, not just sounds brilliant. You must be dedicated, enthusiastic, and committed to it. It can be something to do with your business, or it could be something profits are diverted to. Don't simply scratch your head... who has inspired you for their accomplishments? Why? In your perfect world, what would your brand represent to people? It doesn't have to be out of this world, like creating a city on Mars (though it could). It could be shoes for all the homeless, instantaneous delivery, or even ending war...

In order to enjoy the process of creating a SEXY brand vision, imagine an energy form called 'Unobtainium.' It got that name because it's pretty unobtainable. Your SEXY brand vision needs to be exciting, not far-fetched, realistic, and not pie in the sky. It needs to inspire, enthrall, and captivate people's attention. Your goal is to paint a picture your brand desires to accomplish sometime in the future. This brand vision is to be considered the ultimate destination—the zenith of your brand accomplishment.

When deciding on your brand vision, take a look at the vision of some of your favorite brands. Discuss your ideas with trusted colleagues. No internet search can tell you if your sexy brand vision is good or bad, realistic or ridiculous, but you will know when you share it. Your challenge is to determine just how inspired people are with your sexy brand vision. Make sure you are not just telling family and friends who will say it's great because they love you. You must test your ideas with strangers and be completely open to their feedback, no matter how critical. This step will set you up for success. Knowing where you are going is vital to keeping momentum. Knowing and being dedicated to your brand vision helps with decision-making, strategy, and brand adventure.

Many years ago, I presented at a business owners' event in San Diego. Included in the event was an outdoor excursion team-building experience called a 'Ropes Course.' Of the many challenges, the finale was to climb a telegraph pole, stand on top, then jump and catch a trapeze. I was pretty concerned, especially as everyone at the event knew me because I had run two 3-hour workshops with them.

As I ascended the pole, it got scarier and scarier. Two feet from the top, the foot spikes ended, and the only way to get on top of that pole was by overcoming fear and applying pure willpower. For me, the pole was shaking so hard because I was so scared. I even discovered that as the crowd of supportive friends shouted, "You

can do it” and “You got this,” I responded with screams of “fuck off,” “Shut the fuck up,” and “Leave me the fuck alone.” Yes, I learned that when scared, I certainly make myself alone. But, of all things, I did it. Somehow, I made it on top of that telegraph pole. I stood up and raised my arms to the sky. I was so pleased, proud, and fulfilled. And at that moment, I had an epiphany... “How can I give my knowledge to people for almost nothing and still grow a large company.”

I jumped for the trapeze and missed completely. And I didn’t care. I was so happy I made it to the top of the pole and was intrigued by the idea that came into my mind.

That idea stayed and swam around for a few years. Then, one day, I realized just how ready I was for a significant shake-up. I quit being a consultant, started my podcast, and got busy with a documentary series. This brand vision is exciting and powerful for me and those I share it with; it allows me to be true to myself, bring tremendous value to my audience (customers), and help many other types of businesses along the way.

For me, focusing on my sexy brand vision upgraded the entire way I do business, brought my business back to the cutting edge, and made it more exciting. It’s that excitement that attracts customers.

When you work on your Sexy Brand Vision, I urge you to listen to yourself. Most likely, you’ve been hearing a message that

you have ignored because it may have made no sense. In your perfect world, how would you like to do business? How would you like to help your customers? How would you wish to improve the world? Who would you love to be a part of your community?

Use this space to list any questions you have about your Brand vision...

Ultimately, don't we all want to end up laughing all the way to the bank? We focus on how we want to end up (Side note: I met the absolute love of my life in a bar called 'The End Up'). However, just like with the 27-year relationship I've so far enjoyed with my husband Theo, it's the journey that truly is more important than the destination. It's HOW you do it that matters. And when 'how you do it' resonates with your customers, success follows.

I wish for you the wonderment of accomplishing more than you ever dreamed, of making your indelible mark on this world that says "I was here, and look what happened" because together, with the right brand, the right team, the right amount of luck and the decision to go for it, success awaits. It allows you a life of adventure, and it allows you to help others in ways that will make you so happy to be alive, so appreciative of this adventure, and so filled with love that simply by existing, you make the world a better place.

This is your legacy.

David